Finding Wonderland

by Jane Nicolaas



Finding Wonderland by Jane Nicholaas

ISBN: 978-1-61387-030-3

Copyright 2010 by SpeechGeek.

Free performance of this play for high school and college level competitive forensics is permitted. All other rights reserved.

This PDF version of this selection, e-published in 2011, is identical to the printed published version of this same publication dated 2011. This statement along with the entire printed PDF of this publication must be presented at any National Forensic League District or National event for the script to comply with NFL rules per the request of the Executive Director.

This and other selections of quality performance literature for competitive oral interpretation are published by SpeechGeek.

For more information and performance rights, contact **SpeechGeek.**

SpeechGeek
806 Brownstone Way
Bowling Green, KY 42104

Phone: 1-888-742-2028
Email: thegeek@speechgeek.com
Web: www.speechgeek.com
Facebook: www.facebook.com/speechgeek

(A knock at the door.)

LIDDELL. Mr. Dodgson, welcome to our home.
CARROLL. Thank you, Liddell. Your husband thought it opportune to invite me to sit with your young daughter.
LIDDELL. Quite. I am told it will do wonders for my sanity.
CARROLL. *(nods)*
LIDDELL. Rather meek, I see.
CARROLL. Rather.
LIDDELL. Well, I am sure you will do well to keep our daughter occupied and teach her the ways of gentility.
CARROLL. I am excellent at occupation, madam, except when it comes to keeping one myself.
LIDDELL. (*not amused*) Mr. Dodgson, let me be clear. I offered you employment in my home because my husband took pity on you, an unmarried man with an unusual sympathy for children and no discernable purpose in life.
CARROLL. Much obliged, madam. It seems you are the last soul in town who is willing to be so gracious.
LIDDELL. Indeed. Please make yourself comfortable; my daughter should be in any moment. Excuse me. (*exits while calling out*) Alice? Alice?

(Alice enters.)

CARROLL. Ah… good day, madam.
ALICE. Good day, sir. And you are?
CARROLL. My name is Mr. Dodgson.
ALICE. Oh, no. That won't do at all. That name sounds like Mr. Dodo. You shall be…Mr. Carroll. Like a song.
CARROLL. Very well. Ms. Liddell and Mr. Carroll.
ALICE. No!
CARROLL. No?
ALICE. No. We are not to be entertained as stuffy old proper people. In here, I shall be Alice and you shall be Lewis.
CARROLL. Very well. In your wonderland, Alice, I am Lewis Carroll.
ALICE. Very pleased to meet you, sir.

INTRO

(He enters, she is pouting on the couch)

CARROLL. Ta-da! A painted rose, just for you! *(She scoffs at the gift.)* Oh dear, someone seems to be in a foul disposition.

ALICE. You are late!

CARROLL. I am? (*checks his watch*)

ALICE. You most certainly are. Does your pocket watch have jam in it?

CARROLL. I don't believe so.

ALICE. You are a quarter of an hour late. I've been waiting here forever.

CARROLL. Well, if I am late, it is entirely because of the *adventure* I had on the way over.

ALICE. (*pouting, but interested*) …Adventure?

CARROLL. Oh, it was magnificent.

ALICE. …In what way?

CARROLL. In the magnificent way. So there I was on a golden afternoon, reading by the river.

ALICE. Stop. Stop. Stop. This story is all wrong. Try again.

CARROLL. You're rather insistent today, are you not?

ALICE. 'Tis not of your concern why a lady demands. You shall do as I say or you shall be punished.

CARROLL. Well, that didn't sound like my little Alice. Sounded quite a lot like your mother.

ALICE. (*pause*) It *was* a golden afternoon, but *I* was sitting by the river.

CARROLL. Indeed you were.

ALICE. And I was being made to listen and be ladylike and bored.

CARROLL. How dreadful.

ALICE. And then… well, go on.

CARROLL. *(He gestures for Alice to sit down on the sofa and carefully walks behind it.)* While you were sitting, something caught your eye.

ALICE. What was it?

CARROLL. *(disappears behind the sofa)* You took a closer look when--from behind a tree--out popped a rabbit. *(pops out from behind the sofa as a rabbit)*

ALICE. Just a rabbit?

CARROLL. *(looks at himself and improvises)* A rabbit in a waistcoat. *(pulls out his pocket watch) …*with a pocket watch.

ALICE. How curious! And then he said…
RABBIT. Oh dear, I'm ever so late.
ALICE. And I thought, what on earth could a rabbit be late for? I must follow him and find out.

(chases him around the room)

RABBIT. Oh dear! Oh dear! I shall be late!
CARROLL. And then the rabbit jumped down a rabbit hole.
ALICE. But I followed him, didn't I?
CARROLL. You did, but it wasn't a normal rabbit hole; it was the deepest in the whole world, so you jumped in and you fell. And you fell and you fell!

(She twirls her as if she's tumbling down the rabbit hole)

ALICE. I shall fall right through the center of the earth!
CARROLL. And come out where people walk upside down.

(Both laugh hysterically. She spins away just as mother enters.)

LIDDELL. What is the meaning of this?

(Both stop immediately.)

LIDDELL. I could hear you both clear out in the garden! Alice, you know better than to conduct yourself this way. And you, Mr. Dodgson—
CARROLL. Uh…
ALICE. Mr. Carroll, actually.
CARROLL. Alice…
LIDDELL. I beg your pardon?
ALICE. It's true, Mama! Every time he enters the house, the most miraculous thing happens: he is transformed from the meek and mild Mr. Dodgson into the fantastic Mr. Lewis Carroll.
LIDDELL. Alice you shame yourself with such an outburst. Apologize this instant.
CARROLL. There is no call for apology. It is just a game, madam. I can assure you, just nonsense.
ALICE. *Just*?
LIDDELL. Alice, I think your visit is at an end for today. Say goodbye to mister. … whatever your name has become.
ALICE. But he only just arrived!

LIDDELL. You shall do as I say, or you shall be punished.

ALICE. Good day, sir.

CARROLL. Good day. (*kneels and says quietly so only she may hear*) Don't worry. You're down the rabbit hole now, remember? There are many adventures to come.

(*Alice smiles widely and skips from the room. Leaving Carroll to the mercy of Liddell.*)

LIDDELL. As for you, sir. You would do well to remember that I am your employer and keeping me satisfied is the only means to continue your appointment in this household. Good day.

CARROLL. Good day, madam.

(He dejectedly leaves.)

TRANSITION

CARROLL. Ms. Alice? You're six feet taller than last I saw you. What have you been eating?

ALICE. *(Alice stands uncomfortably still with her hands behind her back. She is happy to see him, but is fearful and quiet.)*

CARROLL. Speechless? A first. Still tumbling down the rabbit hole?

ALICE. I'm afraid not, sir. 'Tis not very ladylike to entertain such fancy.

(He catches sight of her hands. They are swollen and badly bruised beneath bandages. The look shared between them conveys the story; she has been punished with a cane.)

CARROLL. My dear child. *(gently takes a hand)* What have they done to you? *(she says nothing)* They've gone mad.

ALICE. It seems the whole world has.

CARROLL. Well, you can't go running round mad people all the time. Remember the last time that happened? *(she doesn't)* Of course you do. It was down the rabbit hole: the Mad Hatter and the March Hare?

ALICE. *(smiles a little)* Oh yes, how could I forget such an adventure. Remind me again of what came to be?

CARROLL. You needed directions.

ALICE. When I came across a tea party! Excuse me, sirs. Have you seen the White Rabbit?

HATTER. Yes, of course! Would you like some wine?

HARE. We don't have any.

HATTER. Precisely why I asked if she'd like some.

(Hatter and Hare laugh obnoxiously.)

ALICE. I don't think—

HATTER. Then you shouldn't talk then.

(Hatter and Hare laugh obnoxiously.)

ALICE. I think you're dreadfully savage and mad. And I imagine, if the Queen were here, —

HATTER. The Queen?

ALICE. Yes, the Queen of Hearts. If she were here, she'd say off with your hands!

HATTER. No, she'd say off with your heads!

(Alice and Carroll laugh. They hear something and instantly go silent with fear. A moment passes and it seems they are safe.)

ALICE. Nevermind, Mother is playing bridge with her friends across town.

CARROLL. The Queen of Hearts, eh?

ALICE. She thinks me too old for rhymes and stories. You're not too old for fantasy; why should I be?

CARROLL. Well, my dear. Most believe I am too old for nonsense. That is why they look at me the way they do. You should hear some of the things they have said about me. Horrible, dreadful things.

ALICE. None of them are true.

CARROLL. Isn't that silly? They take no time to enjoy fantastic nonsense, and yet they seem to revel in malicious nonsense fully.

(He looks at her, she has no idea what he is talking about)

CARROLL. Alice, I want you to know something. Something very secret. Is the secret safe with you?

ALICE. Of course.

CARROLL. The world is a dark place for dreamers. Sometimes it makes the shadows seem like they're all around you. But someone very wise once told me that dark is the best place for dreams because that is where they are most needed. Do you understand?

ALICE. I can't say I do, sir.

CARROLL. You will. I'm sorry to say you will.

ALICE. Why do you tremble so much? You act so meek and scared all the time.

CARROLL. I'm afraid it is my nature.

ALICE. No sir, your nature is the same as mine. I have seen it.

CARROLL. Perhaps it is what I was taught by the natures of those around me.

ALICE. (*laughs at the silliness*) To be taught by nature. As if…as if some little caterpillar were meant to teach you how to be you.

CARROLL. Yes, and I'm sure even they would look down their petals at me.

ALICE. You have no need to be scared when you have such a wonderful fantasy world to live in.

CARROLL. My dear, the fantasy world is yours. I am simply running through it as a scared little rabbit.

ALICE. Well, then we must take the stand.

CARROLL. Do you mean take *a* stand?

ALICE. A trial! Begin, little rabbit.

CARROLL. Very well!

RABBIT. Hear ye! Hear ye! All rise to receive Her Majesty, the Queen of Hearts.

QUEEN. Call the first witness, The Mad Hatter!

HATTER. I beg pardon, your Majesty, but I hadn't quite finished my tea. We only just started on…the… uh…fourteenth of March.

HARE. …Fifteenth…

HATTER. Four fifths of a tenth of march

(Hatter and Hare laugh obnoxiously.)

QUEEN. You're full of nonsense. Off with your head!

RABBIT. But… but… but… your Majesty!

QUEEN. 'Tis not of your concern why a lady demands. You shall do as I say or you shall be punished. Off with your head!

RABBIT. You heard what the Queen said! Off with our heads!

CARROLL. Do you suppose we'll still be mad with no heads?

ALICE. I do hope so.

CARROLL. So do I.

TRANSITION

(Carroll enters excitedly to find Mrs. Liddell waiting for him.)

LIDDELL. Ah, Mr. Dodgson. Thank you for joining me today.

CARROLL. Of course. Is she about? I've brought her a present.

LIDDELL. I'm afraid you will not see my daughter today.

CARROLL. I see.

LIDDELL. …Or ever again. I have discussed the matter with my husband, and we feel that the function you serve in our household is no longer necessary.

CARROLL. And does Alice feel that way?

LIDDELL. *Miss Liddell*, sir, is a child and an incorrigible one at that.

CARROLL. I disagree to the negativity you paint both of those words in.

LIDDELL. Regardless, her antics have not improved since your arrival. In many ways, it seems to have given them new vigor. She has given us no other choice. She is to be sent to boarding school.

CARROLL. Boarding school?

LIDDELL. Where she shall remain until she is of age to attend university.

CARROLL. But…but she could be tutored here.

LIDDELL. Don't be ridiculous.

CARROLL. I, myself, am an excellent mathematician.

LIDDELL. Just as you are an excellent elocutionist? (*brings out a piece of paper*) "Twas brillig, and the slithy toves did gyre and gimble in the wabe." Complete twaddle. You are--I'm afraid--as incorrigible as she is.

CARROLL. I consider there to be no finer compliment.

LIDDELL. Watch your tone, sir.

CARROLL. Very well. I am no longer employed here. May I come to call as a visitor to Ms. Liddell?

LIDDELL. Most certainly not! What on earth would people say?

CARROLL. Why does that matter so much to you?

LIDDELL. You're mad. It seems to me, sir, that you should leave now.

CARROLL. It seems to *me*, madam, that you are unworthy of a daughter such as Alice.

LIDDELL. Sir!

CARROLL. Yes, and while we are being clear and truthful, I would like you to know that I am an unmarried man who enjoys the company of children

because it means that I am required to spend less time with the likes of you and your incipit adultness.

LIDDELL. You are too bold, sir.

CARROLL. Your daughter is full of fire and life and wonder. And while I deeply regret that she will be sent away, I take solace in the fact that she will no longer be subjected to your ludicrous expectations and harsh disciplines.

LIDDELL. You are out of order!

CARROLL. Well then off with my head, you royal witch!

LIDDELL. Mr. Dodgson!

CARROLL. Madam, that is the name of a meek and pathetic man--two things I am no longer.

LIDDELL. You are full of nonsense!

CARROLL. And I thank God and Alice every day for it! Good day and good riddance, madam.

(Turns and finds Alice standing there in silence.)

CARROLL. Alice.

ALICE. I heard what you've said.

CARROLL. Yes, well. At some time we all have to grow up and take "the" stand, I suppose.

ALICE. I suppose.

CARROLL. Where are you to go for boarding school?

ALICE. I don't know; they haven't told me where, only that I am going.

CARROLL. Well, I'm sure it will be wonderful with you there.

ALICE. Thank you for everything, Mr. Dodgson.

CARROLL. Mr. Dodgson? Who is that stodgy old proper person?

ALICE. He is…the most brilliant person I have ever met. He is my best friend. And I shall miss him terribly.

CARROLL. *(kneels down before her)* My dear, sweet child. There is no need to miss me. *(hands her the present)*

ALICE. What is this? *(opens it) Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*. You've made us into a book?

CARROLL. You see? Whenever you feel alone or scared or bored by the world around you, you can go here and live one of our magnificent adventures again.

ALICE. I shall never see you again, shall I?
CARROLL. And yet I'll always be with you.
ALICE. Thank you.
CARROLL. For the book?
ALICE. For believing in my nonsense.
CARROLL. Thank you for believing in mine.

(They share an embrace and he gently kisses her forehead before he departs. She stares for a moment and then opens the book to the end.)

ALICE. "Lastly, she pictured the dream of Wonderland: remembering her own child life and the happy summer days."

(Alice closes the book lovingly.)